

Context Matters: Ethical Challenges in Research with Online Communities

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Abstract

While online community research is prevalent in CSCW, there are limited ethical principles for conducting research that may affect online communities. At the same time, a growing body of evidence suggests that traditional ethical review focused on research with individuals fails to fully capture the complexities of online community research. To support advancing ethical online community research, we propose a one-day hybrid workshop centered around tensions and challenges in adopting best practices for ethical online community research. This workshop aims to bring together online community researchers to 1) recognize existing approaches for ethical online community research, 2) expose gaps in current practices, and 3) prioritize directions to reconcile these ethical challenges.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Collaborative and social computing theory, concepts and paradigms; HCI theory, concepts and models.**

Keywords

Ethics, online communities, internet research

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1 Introduction

The ways we conduct social computing research not only shape the rigor and validity of our findings but also carry profound implications, influencing the individuals, communities, and broader populations we study. The CSCW community has been concerned with how researchers from a variety of methodological, disciplinary, and cultural backgrounds collect data to empirically understand how people engage with online technologies [25]. At the same time, the field has had ongoing discussions about the ethical implications of research practices themselves, questioning how these methodological choices impact researcher-community dynamics and introduce risks [13, 16–18, 21, 22, 32, 40]. These prior workshops and panels have emphasized critical dimensions of CSCW ethics like power [13], pluralism [40], AI policy [21], public scholarship [22], volunteer work [32], CSCW best practices [16–18], and industry-academia data sharing [28]. This workshop aims to continue these discussions—drawing on themes related to research communication, equity, and CSCW norms—to help develop better practices for research with online communities.

Online communities are a central stakeholder in CSCW research. Our field has an extended history of studying online groups, generating insights that inform the design of these spaces, and increasingly is relying on more data produced within online communities [9, 10, 24, 37, 38, 44]. While ethical research with individuals has received extensive attention [15, 35, 36], a growing body of research suggests that policies for human subjects research fail to fully address the complexities of internet research [18, 19, 47]. High-profile ethical breaches in news headlines provide evidence of this mismatch. In one example, the r/ChangeMyView community expressed outrage upon learning that researchers at the University of Zurich covertly used the platform to run a persuasion experiment with a large language models. In this case, researchers defended their methods by citing IRB approval and the perceived broader

impacts of the work, stating, “*We believe, however, that given the high societal importance of this topic, it was crucial to conduct a study of this kind, even if it meant disobeying the rules.*” [5]. This recent example echos a broader pattern of online community research controversy in the Linux Hypocrite Commits [11], Facebook Emotional Contagion [23], Princeton-Radboud Study on Privacy Law Implementation [27], and the sale of sensitive Crisis Text Line data [31]. Still, the human subjects lens remains a predominant narrative used to evaluate online community research ethics [20]. While a variety of alternative lenses and recommendations exist for studying individuals online [2, 3, 14, 20, 47], challenges remain in encouraging the widespread adoption of these approaches. Moreover, we invite more research to develop frameworks and practices that help researchers systematically account for the impact of their work on online communities as a whole, extending beyond individuals.

In light of this call, our proposed workshop aims to bring together online community researchers to support the advancement of ethical online community research with the following goals:

- (1) Recognize unique contexts of, approaches to, and ethical frameworks for online community, in and out of CSCW.
- (2) Expose gaps and barriers to adoption in existing practices for research with online communities and propose avenues for reconciling these ethical challenges.
- (3) Prioritize high-impact directions for future ethics research in CSCW and foster opportunities for collaboration.

We invite interested online community and ethics researchers from all backgrounds to submit a position paper reflecting on how their research context shapes the approaches, methods, and ethical considerations they bring to online community research. We encourage participants to critically examine the barriers to integrating a community lens to research ethics in CSCW. No prior ethics research experience is required.

2 Workshop Themes

2.1 A Contextual Approach to Online Community Research

In recent years, CSCW and the field have developed a rich set of ethical frameworks and best practices that, to a large degree, build on the narrative that context matters [2, 14, 20, 47]. Together, this approach emphasizes that ethical review is more than a check box—*guidelines, not recipes* [1]. Related to online communities, these works encourage researchers to redefine the *subjects* we account for in ethical discourse and consider impacts as they manifest downstream and to communities [2, 20]. When research takes this contextual approach, they may find ways community norms differ from common research practices. For instance, these efforts have revealed a variety of nuanced interpretations of privacy related to data sharing [14], anonymity [41], and desires for public recognition [8].

By nature, how researchers embody this contextual approach to research ethics will vary between contexts, communities, and methodologies. Still, a number of recommendations exist to help facilitate contextual integrity in CSCW research. In practice, applying data minimization [2], using action research methods [20], and developing codes of conduct [48] all consider the unique contexts

in which internet research is conducted, along with the expectations that accompany them. Zimmer demonstrates how to apply Nissenbaum’s contextual integrity heuristics in the context of big data research in communities. While these examples emphasize researchers’ responsibility to understand and adapt to community contexts, another perspective presents a community-driven approach to guiding researchers’ understanding. Here, feminists and participatory methodologies question who defines ethical boundaries in research and propose strategies to pursue equity in science [7]. Drawing from offline community research, community-based participatory research attempts to shift research power dynamics with long-term collaborations and community-driven research inquiry [29]. In response to research violations, some online communities are creating their own policies and guidelines to promote transparency and clarify their contextual standards. [4, 6]. Inspired by these community-driven mechanisms, recent work in CSCW introduces the FACTORS framework to help researchers and online communities develop lasting practices for navigating community-level research impacts [46]. The framework outlines four functions/recurring roles supported by distributed cognition between researchers and online communities to facilitate ethical research engagement (i.e., teaching norms, overseeing rules, reciprocating value, and sustaining resources).

This workshop theme invites participants to share their experiences with online community research with the goal of exploring how different ethical lenses help them navigate the community-level impacts of their research and how these approaches can help CSCW recognize ethical online community practices.

2.2 Tensions and Challenges in Ethical Online Community Research

As CSCW continues to expand its ethical considerations for research with online communities, it must actively engage with the unique ethical tensions that arise when conducting research in the diverse range of online spaces in which CSCW research occurs. A primary challenge in introducing new ethical lenses is navigating the conflicting positions between alternative frameworks, which can create barriers to their application and limit their benefits. We ask when and where gaps arise and what research directions merit more attention to reconcile these ethical dilemmas.

One source of tension emerges when researchers’ value commitments conflict with those of the communities they study. Recent work within CSCW illustrates the scientific and social importance of studying mechanisms of resistance in extremism [39], conspiracy [45], and disinformation communities [43]. While aligning research with community expectations is an important aspect of navigating community-level impacts [46], overemphasizing this alignment risks reinforcing dominant narratives and overlooking marginalized voices, particularly in studies that critically examine harmful ideologies [12]. Recent work within CSCW has explored value-based ethical dilemmas in offline communities, offering a conflict-avoidant method for designing for shared values [26], but this approach may not be feasible when research implications fundamentally contradict community goals. Similar value tensions

emerge when considering community desires for visible accountability in research and risks research as a result of public scholarship [33, 46].

Navigating community-level impacts of research has led to engagement-heavy recommendations inspired by participatory methods, yet implementing these approaches remains challenging across different research contexts. Collaborating with moderators, organizers, and community guardians is an effective method for mediating researcher community relationships [42], but it also places additional labor demands on communities [20, 46]. In large, even small burdens can quickly scale across projects, making sustained participatory methods and research oversight increasingly difficult. While community-driven research guidelines may be desirable in these contexts, small and new communities may not have the experience or capacity to develop such frameworks. Similar difficulties emerge in decentralized and latent communities, where there may be no clear representatives to engage with and permeable community boundaries muddy researchers' ability to assess community-level impacts [30, 34]. Finally, we highlight a mismatch between deep engagement with communities and institutional incentives to publish and secure funding—a gap that may be even more pronounced between different subfields in social computing—or a related mismatch between specific communities' values and industry incentives to protect or grow their baselines through product development.

In light of these complexities, we invite participants to critically reflect on the applicability and limitations of the available ethical frameworks and best practices for the research of online communities. What role do these frameworks play in shaping the ways CSCW conducts research, and how can we increase their impact in practice?

3 Workshop Activities

We are planning a primarily synchronous, in-person experience to support the workshop's goals. We aim to support a maximum of 25 participants to facilitate ample opportunities for active participation while also adhering to the time constraints of the lightning talk format. While we encourage in-person attendance, in-person attendance is not always possible. If there is enough demand, we will support up to 10 remote participants in a semi-split fashion. Most collaborative activities will be organized so that groups share the same modality. Large group discussions will also be shared on Zoom, with in-person participants using a microphone. This will be a one-day workshop structured according to the schedule outlined in Table 1.

Participants will be required to submit a two-slide presentation one week prior to the workshop. Organizers will use this time to coordinate slides into a single presentation to facilitate seamless and efficient presentations. Participants should use the lightning talk slide template on the workshop website to prepare their slides to ensure consistency between presentations—though personalization is strongly encouraged. Lightning talks should be no more than 3 minutes and include a brief introduction, your experience with research with online communities, and a concluding statement on how this workshop group can be most helpful to your work. During the talks, participants will be split into two groups (A & B).

While one group presents, the other will take notes on a shared web whiteboard and identify common themes across the talks. These talks will offer participants an opportunity to become acquainted with each other's research while also seeding collaborative opportunities in the afternoon brainstorming session. Both remote and in-person participants will equally engage in the lightning talks, with all presentation slides and audio being shared simultaneously via Zoom and in-person. After the talks, we will collectively review the web whiteboard and discuss common themes that emerged. Participants will self-select into topic-based brainstorming groups for the afternoon—if applicable, remote participants will collectively select a topic for their group.

In the afternoon, organizers will group participants by affinity based on their lightning talk & workshop submission. All groups will utilize a shared web whiteboard during this collaborative activity. The boards will be seeded with notes from the morning lightning talks. This tool offers remote and in-person participants the opportunity to record discussion points, brainstorm ideas, and prioritize high-impact directions for future CSCW ethics research. We encourage groups to use this artifact during their group share-out at the end of the workshop. Additionally, a PDF copy will be preserved and shared with all participants. The goal of this activity is two-fold: 1) connect new and experienced researchers to facilitate short and long-term collaboration opportunities to advance ethical internet research, and 2) prioritize high-impact next steps for the broader field in increasing the impact and practice of ethical online community research.

4 Organizers

Matthew Zent is a Ph.D. candidate at the University of Minnesota. His research is centered around understanding how online community norms shape the design and research of sociotechnical systems. In his work, he has explored the effects of anonymity on social support outcomes in online recovery, designed privacy-preserving tools and approaches for data sharing in edtech, and developed an ethical framework for navigating community-level impacts of research.

Stevie Chancellor is an Assistant Professor in the Computer Science & Engineering Department at the University of Minnesota. Her research focuses on human-centered AI for mental illness prediction in social media data, with a specific focus on ethical AI in socially contentious prediction scenarios. She has also served on the SIGCHI Research Ethics Committee since 2023 and run numerous workshops on research ethics in CS venues.

Casey Fiesler is an Associate Professor of Information Science at University of Colorado Boulder. She researches and teaches in the areas of technology ethics, internet law and policy, and online communities. One of her major focus areas is ethics for online research, and she has also been a member (and former chair) of the SIGCHI research ethics committee since 2016.

Sarah Gilbert is a research associate at Cornell University and Research Director of the Citizens and Technology Lab where her work focuses on supporting healthy online communities. Using collaborative methods, she explores how volunteer moderators' labor impacts community governance, factors and interventions

Time	Activity
9:00 - 9:15	Welcome and Introduction
9:15 - 9:45	Opening Keynote
9:45 - 10:30	Lightning talks (A) Group A gives 3-minute talks highlighting how this workshop group can be most helpful to your work. Group B records and affinity maps lightning talk themes.
10:30 - 11:00	Coffee Break
11:00 - 11:45	Lightning talks (B)
11:45 - 12:00	Group Selection Group discussion about emerging topics from the lightning talks. Participants self-select into topic-based brainstorming groups.
12:00 - 13:30	Lunch Break Participants are encouraged to eat with members of their group and break the ice!
13:30 - 14:15	Group Brainstorming Session Participants will join their topic-based brainstorming groups. Collaboration will utilize a shared web whiteboard and focus on high-impact directions for future work.
14:15 - 14:30	Break
14:30 - 15:15	Group Presentation Groups deliver 5-minute share out presentations of their web whiteboard.
15:15 - 15:45	Open Discussion Semi-structured large-group discussion time to respond to group presentations. The group reflects on the key takeaways of the workshop.
15:45 - 16:00	Closing Remarks Organizers conclude with a discussion about next steps.

Table 1: The workshop structure.

that encourage participation and reduce harmful behaviour, and studies how online data can be reused ethically.

Mohammad Rashidujjaman Rifat is a Computer Science Ph.D. candidate at the University of Toronto and an incoming Assistant Professor of Tech Ethics and Global Affairs at the Keough School of Global Affairs and the Department of Computer Science and Engineering at the University of Notre Dame. Rifat studies ethics in computing through postsecular, postcolonial, and decolonial perspectives, with the aim of designing and evaluating technologies that are inclusive of plural ethics and that empower marginalized communities. He has organized workshops on ethical pluralism at CSCW and CHI.

C. Estelle Smith is an Assistant Professor of Computer Science at the Colorado School of Mines in Golden, Colorado. She directs a research lab focused on developing a new subfield for Human-Computer Interaction in online spiritual care, requiring careful attention to multi-faith design contexts and ethical pluralism. She has served in various organizing and service roles for CSCW, including as Communications Chair, Community Chair, Associate Chair, and prior organizer of workshops on public scholarship and research ethics.

Svetlana “Lana” Yarosh is an Associate Professor in the Computer Science & Engineering Department at the University of Minnesota, focusing on social connectedness in critical contexts such as recovery from substance use disorders. Her work with recovery communities online and offline has highlighted the importance of research ethics and community engagement.

Seraphina Yong is a Ph.D. candidate at the University of Minnesota. Her research focuses on understanding how different technologies can support or impact humans’ mutual understanding and relationship building. Her work has involved delineating the sociotechnical dynamics of technology-mediated friendship development, as well as how emerging technologies like VR and AI play a role in perceptions within personal relationships.

Michael Zimmer is the Director of the Center for Data, Ethics, and Society at Marquette University, and Professor & Vice-Chair in the Department of Computer Science. He is a privacy and data ethics scholar whose work focuses on digital privacy & surveillance, the ethics of big data, and internet research ethics. He currently serves on the SIGCHI Research Ethics Committee and is Chair of the AoIR Ethics Working Committee.

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